have no experience in – neither in its production, taste, nor consumption patterns.1

Norden's concerns were valid as soon after, a storm of public criticism broke out. The Stasi reported it was evident that the 'quality and price of the new coffee variety 'Kaffee-Mix' was being rejected by broad sections of the population'.

To make matters worse, the 'mix' could not be percolated in older coffee machines still common in cafés and canteens. And as if that wasn't bad enough, 'Kaffee-Mix' (sarcastically referred to as 'Erich's Krönung') swelled into a thick, sticky goo, clogging filters. Bitterness over the issue was the cause of frequent arguments and anonymous hate mail. Once coined, the term 'Erich's Krönung' – a play on a much-loved Western coffee brand – was to have a long life. In a secret meeting of the SED leadership, Honecker indicated that GDR customs would allow more coffee to come in private parcels from the FRG and in the luggage of visitors than provided for in the regulations. 'The more coffee from the West that comes into the GDR, the less has to be imported,' Honecker concluded.2

These parcels, known as Westpakete, were sent by West Germans to their friends and families in East Germany and usually contained coffee, food, soap, spirits, confections and other goodies. Although much desired, they were occasionally the subject of jokes:

Erich Honecker wants to see how popular he is among the population, so he rings people's doorbells. A boy opens one and asks: 'Who are you?' Erich bends down: 'I'm the one who makes sure that you have a TV and always enough to eat!' – 'Mama, hurry, Uncle Frank from Hamburg is here!'

It is estimated that Westpaket parcels met about 20 per cent of East German coffee needs. When the heat finally subsided on the 'Kaffee-Mix' debacle, the SED withdrew the concoction from the market. But no sooner had the